

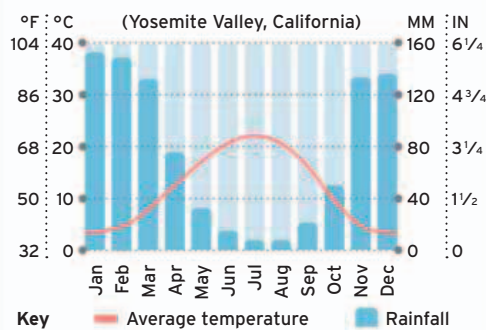
LOCATION



The Sierra Nevada mountains sweep south along the eastern flank of California, with a spur, the Carson Range, edging into Nevada.

CLIMATE

A temperate Mediterranean climate is heavily influenced by altitude, with warm summers and cool winters. Most precipitation falls in the west.



Bighorn sheep

Ovis canadensis

long hairs cover woolly coat



This North American wild sheep is named for the adult male's immense curling horns, which grow to more than 3 ft (1 m) in length. The rams establish a hierarchy based on horn size, with older sheep taking the lead. When it is too close to call, the rivalry is resolved with a head-butting battle. Females grow smaller horns that sweep back from the head. They are mainly defensive, used to deter predators such as eagles and pumas.

High living

In summer, bighorn sheep graze in high mountain meadows. They leap from ledge to ledge, never slipping on the steep, rough ground—their forked hooves split apart as they press down on the ground and grip the rock that fills the gap between them. As winter approaches, the chief ram leads his band of about 10 sheep to lower ground, where they join together to form herds of as many as 100 individuals. The hard outer rim of the bighorn sheep's hooves cut into snow and ice to provide a better grip. Breeding takes place in the valleys, and lambs are born in spring, a few weeks before the bands trek back up to the peaks.

- ↔ 3–6 ft (1–1.8 m)
- ⚖ 132–320 lb (60–145 kg)
- ⊗ Vulnerable
- 🌿 Forbs, grasses, shrubs
- 🏠



▽ CURVED HORNS

The ram's horns keep growing, and can get so large that the tips impede its field of view. Older rams rub down the tips on a rock to keep them short.



horns of large ram weigh more than his skeleton



LAND OF GIANTS
The largest single trees on Earth depend on two small animals to reproduce. The larvae of a wood-boring beetle and the Douglas squirrel both eat giant sequoia cones, resulting in a steady rain of seeds to the forest floor below.

GIANT SEQUOIA

